



ModForge

AI Mod & Asset Toolkit

The Complete Beginner's Guide

Version 0.4.0 · Windows

No experience needed. If you can open a folder and click a button, you can use this guide.

1. What is ModForge?

ModForge is a free program for your Windows PC that helps you look at and change the settings files that games (and other apps) use — safely, without needing to be a programmer. Games often store their settings in plain text files. Normally you'd have to open those in Notepad and carefully hand-edit confusing text. ModForge opens them as a neat list of settings you can change like filling in a form, and it **always makes a backup first** so you can't break anything permanently.

It also bundles four more tools for gamers and modders. Everything lives in one window with tabs across the top — like a Swiss Army knife where each fold-out tool does one job.

TIP — You do NOT need to know what "JSON" or "config" means to use ModForge. There's a plain-English glossary at the end of this guide (Section 12) if you ever see a word you don't recognize.

2. The five tools (tabs)

Across the top of ModForge are five tabs. Here's what each one is for, in plain terms:

Tab	What it's for
Editor	Open a game's settings/save file and change values as simple fields. Makes a backup every time you save.
Converter	Turn one type of settings file into another type (for when a guide or tool wants a different format).
Log Explainer	Paste a scary crash/error message and get a plain-English explanation of what went wrong and how to fix it.
Planner	Plan a character build or loadout: list parts with a cost and a value, stay under a budget, get an AI review.
Tracker	Keep a log of anything (runs, playtime, drops) and see totals, your best, and a daily streak.

NOTE — The Editor, Converter, and Planner/Tracker work fully offline. Only the AI features (the buttons that say things like "Explain" or "AI review") need the internet and an optional key — see Section 5.

3. Installing ModForge

Installing is just running one file. Here's exactly what to do:

- 1 Download **ModForge_0.4.0_x64-setup.exe** (from the Releases page or wherever you got this guide).
- 2 Double-click that file. A small installer window opens.
- 3 Click through it (Next / Install). It installs just for you — **no administrator password needed**.
- 4 When it finishes, ModForge is in your Start Menu. Click it to open.

HEADS UP — Windows may show a blue box that says "**Windows protected your PC.**" This is NOT a virus warning — it appears for every new app that hasn't paid for a "signing certificate" yet. To continue: click "**More info**", then the "**Run anyway**" button that appears. That's it.

Don't want to install anything? There's also a portable **ModForge.exe** you can just double-click to run from any folder — no installation.

4. A quick look at the window

When ModForge opens you'll see three parts:

- **The top bar** — the ModForge logo on the left, and the five tabs (Editor, Converter, Log Explainer, Planner, Tracker). Click a tab to switch tools.
- **The middle** — the tool you're currently using.
- **The bottom strip** — a status line that tells you what just happened ("Saved · backup made", "Converted JSON to YAML", etc.).

TIP — Whenever you're unsure whether something worked, glance at that bottom status strip — it confirms every action.

5. Turning on the AI helper (optional)

Some buttons in ModForge use AI (powered by Claude) to explain files, review builds, or decode crash logs. These are optional. To use them you provide your own free-to-create API key. Here's how:

- 1 In a web browser, go to **console.anthropic.com** and sign up / log in.
- 2 Find **Settings > API Keys** and create a new key. It's a long code starting with "sk-ant-". Copy it.
- 3 In ModForge, go to the **Editor** tab. On the right is the **AI assistant** panel — click **settings**.
- 4 Paste your key, choose a model, and click **Save settings**.

NOTE — Your key is stored only on your PC. Using the AI may cost a small amount on your Anthropic account (usually a fraction of a cent per question). If you never add a key, everything else in ModForge still works.

Which model? "Sonnet" is a good balanced default. "Haiku" is fastest/cheapest. "Opus" is the most thorough. You can switch anytime.

6. The Editor (the main tool)

This is what ModForge is really about: changing a game's settings safely.

Walk-through example:

- 1 Click **Open file...** and pick a settings or save file (for example a *.json*, *.ini*, or *.cfg*).
- 2 ModForge shows every setting as a row: the setting's name on the left, its value in the middle.
- 3 Find the value you want to change and just type a new one. (On/off settings show a checkbox.)
- 4 Click **Save**. Done — the game will use your new value next time it loads.

Handy buttons:

- **Filter fields** — a search box to quickly find a setting by name (type "speed" to jump to speed-related settings).
- **Undo / Redo** — step backward or forward through your changes. Experiment freely.
- **Duplicate (■)** — makes a copy of a repeating item (e.g. add another weapon, sail, or slot in one click).
- **Delete (X)** — removes a setting or item.
- **Backup on save** — a checkbox (on by default). Leave it on!

TIP — Big text files or unknown "binary" files still open — you'll see the raw text or a read-only hex view so you can look, even if there are no editable fields.

7. The Converter

Sometimes a mod guide gives you settings in one format but your game wants another. The Converter translates between them.

- 1 Open the **Converter** tab.
- 2 Paste your text on the left (or click **Load file...**). ModForge auto-detects the format.
- 3 On the right, pick the format you want to convert *to*.
- 4 Click **Convert**. Then **Copy** the result or **Save as...** a file.

NOTE — Supported formats: JSON, YAML, TOML, INI, XML, and CSV. If it can't understand your input, it tells you what's wrong instead of guessing.

8. The Log Explainer

When a game or mod crashes, it usually spits out a wall of confusing text (a "crash log"). This tool turns that into a clear answer.

- 1 Open the **Log Explainer** tab.
- 2 Paste the crash text on the left (or **Load log file...**).
- 3 Click **Explain error**.
- 4 Read the answer on the right: **Cause** (what went wrong), **Fix** (what to do), and **Why**.

NOTE — This uses the AI helper, so you'll need a key set up (Section 5). Long logs are automatically trimmed to the important part.

9. The Planner

A place to plan a build or loadout and make sure it fits a budget.

- 1 Open the **Planner** tab. Give your build a name and set a **Budget** number.
- 2 Click **+ Add part**. For each part, type a name, its **Cost**, and its **Value** (how good it is — any number scale you like).
- 3 Watch the totals bar: it adds up cost vs your budget (turns red if you go over) and shows overall efficiency.
- 4 Click **AI review build** for suggestions on better picks (needs an AI key).

TIP — You can keep several builds and switch between them with the drop-down. They're saved automatically, so they're still there next time you open ModForge.

10. The Tracker

Keep a running log of anything and watch your progress and streaks.

- 1 Open the **Tracker** tab.
- 2 Type a **category** (like "Runs" or "Playtime"), a **value** (a number), and an optional **note**. Click **Log**.
- 3 The cards up top show your total, your best single entry, how many entries you have, and your **day streak**.
- 4 Use the category drop-down to focus on one thing, or **AI analyze** for a trend summary.

NOTE — Everything you log is saved on your PC automatically. Nothing is uploaded unless you press an AI button.

11. Staying safe & fixing problems

Backups — your safety net

Every time you Save in the Editor (with "Backup on save" ticked), ModForge first copies the original file next to itself with a name ending in **.modforge-bak-** and a number. If a change causes a problem, you can restore it:

- 1 Close the game.
- 2 Go to the folder with your file. Find the newest file ending in *.modforge-bak-...*
- 3 Delete your changed file, then rename the backup back to the original file name (remove the ".modforge-bak-..." part).
- 4 Start the game — you're back to how it was.

Common questions

- **"Windows protected your PC" on install** — normal for unsigned apps. Click More info > Run anyway (Section 3).
- **An AI button says "no key"** — add your Anthropic key in the Editor's AI settings (Section 5).
- **A file opens but shows no fields** — it's either a plain-text or binary file; you'll see raw/hex text. That's expected.
- **"Parse failed"** — the file isn't quite valid for its format; ModForge shows the raw text so you can still look/edit carefully.
- **The app won't start** — make sure you're on 64-bit Windows 10/11. Try the portable ModForge.exe.

HEADS UP — Golden rule: **always close the game before editing its save files**, and keep "Backup on save" on. Do that and you can experiment without fear.

12. Plain-English glossary

Config file	A file that stores a program's settings (e.g. graphics, controls, gameplay values).
Save file	A file where a game stores your progress and character/ship data.
JSON / INI / TOML / YAML / XML / CSV	Different common formats (styles of writing) for settings files. ModForge handles all of them.
Field	One setting and its value — like one line in a form.
Backup	A safety copy of a file made before you change it, so you can undo.
Binary / hex	A file that isn't plain text (like an image or a packed save). ModForge shows it read-only as "hex".
Mod	A change or add-on to a game made by players.
API key	A private code that lets ModForge use the AI service on your behalf. You create your own for free.
Crash log	The text a program prints when it crashes, describing what went wrong.

That's everything you need to get started. Open a file, make a change, watch the backup appear — and enjoy modding without the fear of breaking things.

ModForge is free and open source (MIT license).